is now seen as a close confidant of AAP's Delhi leadership. In fact, in October, the Enforcement Directorate had raided two of his properties in Punjab as part of its probe into the Delhi excise policy scam. Although the factory management claimed it had been following all effluent discharge norms set by the Punjab Pollution Control Board (PPCB), the farm unions did not budge an inch.

The protest was led by the Samyukt Kisan Morcha (SKM), the coalition of farm unions that had staged the much bigger—and similarly successful—protest on the borders of the national capital in 2020-21 to oppose the central farm laws that were finally repealed in a similar act of capitulation by the Narendra Modi regime. Here, the farmers put on that defiant aspect again, braving the vagaries of the weather, police lathicharge, arrests of several comrades and even high court eviction orders. "The factory was polluting the groundwater, impacting the quality of drinking water and the health of locals, as also our yields," says Surjit Singh Phul, who heads the Bharatiya Kisan Union (BKU-Krantikari). Their anger had gradually shifted towards Mann's regime, whom they accused of siding with the factory management.

The protest outside the Malbros factory is not an isolated one, though. Last March, AAP had swept the Punjab election by bagging 92 seats in the 117-member assembly—with a pivotal role being played by the support of various unions and associations, including those of farmers, truckers, teachers and environmentalists. But now most of these unions have taken to the streets against the AAP regime. To add to the government's woes, administration in the state almost came to a standstill after Punjab Civil Services (PCS) officers went on a mass casual leave in the second week of January to protest the "vindictive" arrest of their colleague N.S. Dhaliwal, secretary, Regional Transport Authority, Ludhiana, by the Vigilance Bureau (VB). The stalemate ended only after the top officer at Mann's office, A. Venu Prasad, sat with

FARMER UNIONS AND OTHER ASSOCIATIONS HAD PLAYED A KEY ROLE IN AAP'S WIN IN PUNJAB. THEY NOW WANT IT TO DELIVER ON VARIOUS FRONTS

these officers to set up a committee under chief secretary V.K. Janjua to draft SOPs to be followed while taking action against civil servants. The IAS and IPS lobbies, too, are upset over the VB going after some of them. After 2008-batch IAS officer Neelima was booked in a corruption case this month, the IAS association in the state decided to pool resources to seek quashing the FIR.

In October-November '22, when Mann was busy campaigning for AAP in Gujarat, farm and labour unions regularly laid siege to his house in Sangrur. October saw a three-week-long dharna by the BKU faction led by Joginder Singh Ugrahan. They had a whole roster of demands, including crop loss relief for farmers. It was only after the government gave a written assurance that Ugrahan lifted the dharna. In November first week, police lathicharged members of the Sanjha Mazdoor Morcha, a platform for Punjab's labour unions, which was protesting outside the CM's house to seek a hike in labour rates. Later, Mann got into a confrontation with another BKU faction led by Jagjit Singh Dallewal, who was triggered by Mann's accusation that farmer unions were organising "paid protests".

Protests, though, are not limited to farmers and labourers. December saw truck operators up in arms, demanding the restoration of their unions. As they blocked vehicles from entering the state at the Shambhu barrier between Haryana's Ambala and Punjab's Rajpura, traffic remained disrupted on NH44—which connects Delhi to Lud-

STIRRED UP

The 10-month-old AAP regime has had a rocky start in Punjab

PRABHJOT GILL



- Since July, farmers were laying siege to a liquor factory in Ferozepur **(right)**, accusing it of polluting the environment. The AAP government finally ordered its closure on Jan. 17
- In October, a BKU faction laid siege to **CM Bhagwant Mann**'s house in Sangrur for three weeks to push for crop loss relief for farmers, among other demands



- In November, police lathicharged labourers led by Sanjha Mazdoor Morcha who were protesting outside the CM's house to seek hike in wages
- In December, truckers demanding the restoration of their unions blocked vehicles from entering the state at the Ambala-Rajpura border on the busy NH-44
- The New Year began with government-aided school employees up in arms over the denial of the Sixth Pay Commission benefits. Later, Punjab Civil Services officers went on mass casual leave to protest Vigilance Bureau action against a colleague.